FIRE EXTINGUISHERS

Legislation, British Standards, how many, how far, maintenance and the foam ban

1. LAW AND STANDARDS (ENGLAND)

- **Regulatory Reform (Fire Safety) Order 2005.** Article 13: appropriate fire-fighting equipment, easily accessible, simple to use and indicated by signs. Article 17: kept under a suitable maintenance system. No numbers: the fire risk assessment decides.
- **BS 5306-8:2023** selection and siting (replaced the 2012 edition on 30 November 2023). **BS 5306-3** commissioning and maintenance. **BS EN 3-7** ratings.

2. HOW MANY: CLASS A (WOOD, PAPER, TEXTILES)

Floor area per storey	Minimum
Up to 50 m²	**1 extinguisher, 26A in total**
50 to 400 m²	**2 or more, 26A combined**
Over 400 m²	**2 or more, floor area × 0.065 = A rating needed**

A 9 litre water extinguisher is 13A, so two make 26A. 500 m² × 0.065 = 32.5A, so three 13A. The number is the length of the test fire in decimetres: 13A is about 1.3 m of wood crib, 26A about 2.6 m. B rating = litres of test fire; F rating = litres of oil.

3. HOW MANY: CLASS F (COOKING OIL)

Oil surface area (m²)	Provision	Oil surface area (m²)	Provision
0.015	**1 × 5F**	0.18	**2 × 40F**
0.02	**2 × 5F**	0.24 to 0.4	**2 × 75F**
0.04	**1 × 25F**	Above 0.4 m²: an automatic fire suppression system is recommended.	
0.06	**1 × 40F**		
0.11	**1 × 75F**		

Measure the exposed surface of the oil, not the fryer's capacity. Wet chemical extinguisher plus a fire blanket for fryers. Never use water, CO_2, powder or ordinary foam on cooking oil.

4. HOW MANY: CLASS B (FLAMMABLE LIQUIDS)

The number and type depend on the **volume of flammable liquid present**, so a **competent, trained person who knows the liquid** must assess it. The assessor should see that information at the visit and check the right extinguishers are in place and maintained. Travel distance 10 m.

5. WHICH EXTINGUISHER FOR WHICH CLASS

Class	Extinguishers available
A solids	Water, foam, multi-purpose (ABC) powder, wet chemical, water mist
B liquids	Foam (contained fires); powder or CO_2 (spills, running fires)
F oil	Wet chemical (some F-rated foam or water mist). Never water, CO_2, powder or ordinary foam
Electrical	CO_2 or powder. Water-based only if labelled safe. Check the label

6. HOW FAR, AND WHERE

Class	Maximum travel distance
Class A	**30 m**
Class B (liquids)	**10 m**
Class F (cooking oil)	**10 m**
Electrical	**30 m (general), 10 m (dedicated)**

- **Take 5 m off for every door** that has to be opened on the way.
- Near exits, corridors and escape routes, so nobody goes further into the building to fetch one. Beside call points; special risks near the hazard, but reachable.
- Where someone can **turn their back on the fire and escape** if it fails.
- **The right type for the fire risk at that spot**, with signs where it is not obvious. Groups of mixed types need a "which to use" sign.
- Wall mounted, handle about 1.5 m high (up to 4 kg) or 1 m (heavier). Protect from damage, theft and corrosion.

7. MAINTENANCE

What	Who	How often
Visual check: in place, accessible, undamaged, gauge, seals, tamper seal	Responsible person or trained staff	**At least monthly**
Basic service: wear, corrosion, all parts; refill if needed	Competent technician (BAFE SP101)	**Every 12 months**
Extended service (strip down, test, refill)	Competent technician	**5 years: water, foam, powder 10 years: CO_2, sealed powder**

- Keep a log of every check, service and fault. Keep the label on the extinguisher.
- **P50 "service-free" units** (Britannia): sealed, 10 year agent guarantee, no technician service, but still a walk-by and a logged annual visual check by trained staff. Tell the insurer.

THE FOAM BAN

PFOA (a "forever chemical") **in AFFF foam extinguishers has been banned across the UK since 4 July 2025.** Take them out of use, do not refill, and dispose of them as hazardous waste with a licensed contractor. Check labels and safety data sheets for PFOA, PFOS or "perfluorinated"; older units (before about 2016) are most at risk. Not all foam is banned. A wider PFAS restriction is proposed but is not yet law in England. Fluorine-free foam, water mist, powder and CO_2 are alternatives.

Checked 12 October 2026. Standards are paid documents; figures are taken from the NSI bulletin on BS 5306-8:2023, BAFE, the Fire Industry Association and fire and rescue service guidance. Check the class F table and distances against BS 5306-8:2023 before relying on them for a client. Sources: Fire Safety Order, Article 13; Making your small non-domestic premises safe from fire; BAFE servicing FAQ; FIA Fact File 99. General information only; it does not replace a fire risk assessment of your premises.

NEED A FIRE RISK ASSESSMENT?
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